

Evidence Quality

Study Guide - Arguments & Sources

1. Learning goal

Judge whether evidence is relevant to a claim and whether the available evidence is sufficient to support the strength and scope of that claim.

2. What this skill means

Relevance asks whether evidence connects to the claim. Sufficiency asks whether there is enough high-quality evidence to justify the conclusion. Evidence can be relevant but still too limited, too narrow, or too confounded to support a broad claim.

3. Do not confuse it with

Do not treat "related" as "enough." One survey, one example, or one short pilot may be relevant but insufficient for a permanent or universal conclusion.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask: "Which evidence is most relevant?", "Why is this evidence insufficient?", "What additional evidence is needed?", or "Which conclusion is best supported by the available evidence?"

5. Repeatable method

- Name the exact claim and its scope.
- Check relevance: does the evidence address that claim directly?
- Check sufficiency: is there enough evidence for how broad or certain the claim is?
- Look for missing comparisons, small samples, short time periods, or competing causes.
- Choose the strongest conclusion the evidence supports - no stronger.

6. Worked example

A company installed refill stations in one office. Bottle purchases declined during the same month, but the cafeteria also stopped selling one bottled-water brand.

Question: Why is the decline relevant but insufficient to prove the refill stations caused the change?

Reasoning: The decline relates to the claim, but another change happened at the same time. The refill stations cannot be isolated as the only cause.

Best answer: Because the evidence is related to bottle use but does not rule out the cafeteria change as another cause.

7. Common traps

- Assuming a large number is automatically strong evidence.
- Ignoring the scope of the claim: one site does not automatically justify all sites.
- Treating correlation as proof of causation.

8. Diagnostic help

- If you chose evidence only because it mentions the topic, ask whether it measures the actual claim.
- If you jumped from a pilot to a permanent conclusion, compare the evidence scope with the claim scope.
- If two changes happened together, ask whether the evidence isolates the proposed cause.

9. Quick check

A four-week pilot reduced paper use in one department by 18 percent.

Does this prove the entire company should permanently adopt the policy?

Check yourself: No. It is relevant evidence, but the short, single-department pilot is not sufficient by itself for a company-wide permanent conclusion.